# GATORBAIT

MAGAZINE · POSTGAME EDITION

## GATORS STUN NO. 7 TEXAS



FINAL · AUSTIN · FLORIDA SCORED 24 STRAIGHT POINTS. OCT. 17, 2026.

PHOTO COURTESY UAA AND HANNAH WHITE

# FLORIDA 27
# TEXAS 24

JONES JR.'S FIRST START · COLUMNS BY FRANZ BEARD AND BUDDY MARTIN

GATORBAITMEDIA.COM

THE GAME · AUSTIN

# GATORS STUN NO. 7 TEXAS 27-24 IN AUSTIN BEHIND JONES JR.

BY THE GATORBAIT MEDIA DESK Oct. 17, 2026



Florida quarterback Tramell Jones Jr. (No. 9) scrambles against Texas in Austin, Oct. 17, 2026. Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

> **"THEY EXECUTED WITH MORE DETAIL, MORE URGENCY, MORE VIOLENCE, MORE STRENGTH."**
>
> JON SUMRALL, POSTGAME PRESS CONFERENCE, AS REPORTED BY FRANZ BEARD

AUSTIN, Texas — Florida walked into Darrell K. Royal–Texas Memorial Stadium on Saturday with a backup quarterback making his first career start, fell behind 17-3, and walked out with the win of its season. The Gators (5-2, 3-2 SEC) scored 24 straight points and held on to beat No. 7 Texas 27-24, sealed in the final two minutes when Myles Graham sacked Arch Manning and knocked the ball loose, and Kanye Clark fell on it at the Texas 39. Tramell Jones Jr. got the start with Aaron Philo out.

His moment came just before halftime. Down 17-3 after a 63-yard punt-return touchdown by Ryan Niblett, Jones converted a fourth-and-12 to Dallas Wilson, added a 14-yard keeper, and found Lacota Dippre for a 7-yard touchdown with 18 seconds left in the half. Florida went to the locker room down 17-10 instead of buried.

The second half belonged to the Gators. Jones hit Dippre again from 8 yards out to tie it at 17, finishing a 15-play, 69-yard drive. While the offense ground Texas down, the defense shut the Longhorns out in the third quarter. Texas managed just 8 total yards in the period.

Patrick Durkin's 28-yard field goal with 10:40 to play gave Florida its first lead, 20-17. Then Jadan Baugh delivered the haymaker: an 11-yard touchdown run with 6:22 left that made it 27-17. Baugh finished with 25 carries for 91 yards, and Durkin was perfect on the day, hitting from 45 and 28 and going 3-for-3 on extra points.

Texas made it interesting late. Manning converted a fourth-and-6 with a 62-yard completion and found Cam Coleman for a 9-yard touchdown with 4:21 remaining to cut it to 27-24. The Longhorns got the ball back with a chance to tie or win. That is when Graham ended it. On second down with 1:58 to play, he got to Manning for a 9-yard sack and stripped the ball. Clark's recovery let Florida run out the clock on the road.

The numbers matched the scoreboard. Florida outgained Texas 313 yards to 272, converted 8 of 19 third downs to the Longhorns' 2 of 10, never turned the ball over and held it for 38:11 to Texas' 21:49. Dippre caught both of Jones's touchdown passes. Florida moves to 5-2 (3-2 SEC); Texas drops to 4-2 (1-2 SEC). Attendance was 103,989.

Sources: ESPN game summary (event 401856724); GatorBait Media Desk postgame story, Oct. 17; Franz Beard (Sumrall quote). Time of Graham's sack and Texas' third-quarter yardage are from the desk story.

## WHY IT FLIPPED

**24-0**

**FLORIDA'S RUN**

Florida scored 24 straight after trailing 17-3, from Dippre's 7-yard catch to Baugh's 11-yard run.

**0**

**FLORIDA TURNOVERS**

Texas lost one: Manning's fumble.

**38:11**

**TIME OF POSSESSION**

Texas held it for 21:49.

# SCORE BY SCORE

Final: Florida 27, No. 7 Texas 24. Highlighted rows are Florida's 24 straight points.

| | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | FINAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **FLORIDA**<br>5-2 (3-2 SEC) | 0 | 10 | 7 | 10 | **27** |
| **NO. 7 TEXAS**<br>4-2 (1-2 SEC) | 10 | 7 | 0 | 7 | **24** |

| WHEN | PLAY | SCORE |
|---|---|---|
| **Q1** | Texas scores on its first two drives, a touchdown and a field goal<br>Beard | **TEX 10, UF 0** |
| **Q2** | Patrick Durkin 45-yard field goal<br>ESPN (only 45-yarder of the day) | **TEX 10, UF 3** |
| **Q2 11:27** | Ryan Niblett 63-yard punt-return touchdown<br>ESPN, time per Beard | **TEX 17, UF 3** |
| **Q2 0:18** | Tramell Jones Jr. to Lacota Dippre, 7 yards<br>ESPN | **TEX 17, UF 10** |
| **Q3 6:50** | Jones to Dippre, 8 yards<br>ESPN | **TIED 17-17** |
| **Q4 10:40** | Durkin 28-yard field goal<br>ESPN | **UF 20, TEX 17** |
| **Q4 6:22** | Jadan Baugh 11-yard run<br>ESPN | **UF 27, TEX 17** |
| **Q4 4:21** | Arch Manning to Cam Coleman, 9 yards<br>ESPN | **UF 27, TEX 24** |
| **Q4 1:58** | Myles Graham sacks Manning, forces fumble; Kanye Clark recovers at the Texas 39<br>Desk story | **Final: UF 27, TEX 24** |

Source: ESPN game summary (event 401856724). Q1 and the 11:27 mark are from Franz Beard's column; the 1:58 mark is from the desk story. The Q2 field goal is the 45-yarder in ESPN's kicking line and is not timed in the summary we pulled.

# BOX SCORE

Darrell K. Royal–Texas Memorial Stadium, Austin · Oct. 17, 2026 · Attendance 103,989

| | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | FINAL |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **FLORIDA**<br>5-2 (3-2 SEC) | 0 | 10 | 7 | 10 | **27** |
| **NO. 7 TEXAS**<br>4-2 (1-2 SEC) | 10 | 7 | 0 | 7 | **24** |

## TEAM STATS

| | FLORIDA | TEXAS |
|---|---|---|
| FIRST DOWNS | 21 | 13 |
| TOTAL YARDS | 313 | 272 |
| PASSING | 155 (22-of-35) | 173 (14-of-20) |
| RUSHING | 158 (46 carries) | 99 (30 carries) |
| THIRD DOWN | 8-of-19 | 2-of-10 |
| FOURTH DOWN | 2-of-2 | 1-of-3 |
| PENALTIES | 7-55 | 1-15 |
| TURNOVERS | 0 | 1 (Manning fumble lost) |
| POSSESSION | 38:11 | 21:49 |

## FLORIDA LEADERS

| | |
|---|---|
| PASSING | Tramell Jones Jr.: 22-of-35, 155 yards, 2 TD, 0 INT |
| RUSHING | Jadan Baugh: 25 carries, 91 yards, 1 TD. Jones: 10 carries, 41 yards |
| RECEIVING | Eric Singleton Jr.: 7 catches, 43 yards. Lacota Dippre: 2 catches, 15 yards, 2 TD |
| KICKING | Patrick Durkin: 2-of-2 on field goals (45, 28), 3-of-3 on extra points |
| PUNTING | Alec Clark: 6 punts, 51.8 average |
| DEFENSE | Myles Graham: 7 tackles. LJ McCray: 4 tackles, 1.5 sacks |

## TEXAS LEADERS

| | |
|---|---|
| PASSING | Arch Manning: 14-of-20, 173 yards, 1 TD, 1 fumble lost |
| RUSHING | Raleek Brown: 8 carries, 47 yards, 1 TD. Hollywood Smothers: 12 carries, 52 yards |
| RECEIVING | Emmett Mosley V: 2 catches, 76 yards. Cam Coleman: 1 TD catch |
| RETURNS | Ryan Niblett: 63-yard punt-return TD |
| DEFENSE | Justin Cryer: 11 tackles |

Source: ESPN game summary (event 401856724). Records: Florida 5-2 (3-2 SEC), Texas 4-2 (1-2 SEC).

COLUMNIST · FRANZ BEARD

# IT WAS A GOOD DAY FOR AN EXORCISM IN AUSTIN

BY FRANZ BEARD Oct. 17, 2026



Florida defenders gang-tackle a Texas ballcarrier in Austin. Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

## "MAKE NO MISTAKE ABOUT IT, THIS WAS A TOTAL TEAM WIN."

Column as published by GatorBait Media (Wix post c16d53be). Sumrall quotes are from his postgame press conference as Franz Beard filed them. Print edition conforms three figures to ESPN: the halftime score was 17-10 (Florida was tied at 17 in the third quarter, not at the half), and Emmett Mosley V is spelled as ESPN lists it.

*"What an excellent day for an exorcism." – Linda Blair as Regan MacNeil in the 1973 film "The Exorcist"*

Perhaps there is a better explanation for the supernatural event that took place at Darrell K. Royal Stadium in Austin, Texas Saturday afternoon, but for the moment, it does indeed seem as if an exorcism took place either in the Florida locker room or on the sidelines. What other rationale is there? Those same Florida Gators whose defense spent the first six weeks of the season doing a dandy impersonation of a demon-possessed unit channeled their inner Doomsday, haunting Arch Manning into a game he will never forget.

Other than the first two drives of the first quarter that produced a TD and a field goal and a desperation heave late in the fourth quarter that led to a touchdown that gave the game a white knuckles feel to it, the heir to the Manning throne was turned into a very ordinary quarterback. The Gators harassed Manning into poor decisions, a few bad throws and a lost fumble just when 7th-ranked Texas was in dire need of a play to fend off an upset of major proportions.

Florida 27, Texas 24. How in the name of all that is sacred did the Gators manage to pull that off? How did a defense that ranked dead last in the SEC and 110th in the nation sack the heir to the fabled Manning throne five times? How did those same guys from that same defense that both Missouri and South Carolina toyed with find the fire, the passion and intensity to leave the Texas O-line in a side of the road heap gasping for air?

"You know what our guys did?" Sumrall asked in the post game press conference. "They executed with more detail, more urgency, more violence, more strength. They finally took it upon themselves to play with that mentality."

And since the defense was so busy re-discovering the age-old principle of beating the other team silly, Florida's offensive line remembered its party invitations and showed up. A little late, mind you, since they spent the first quarter whiffing and flinching away, but it was timely when they, also, cast out the demons of the past two weeks helping Tramell Jones Jr. become the first Florida quarterback to win his first start on the road against a ranked team since Jesse Palmer got a notch in his belt against 6th-ranked Auburn way back in 1997.

Jones played turnover free, completed 22 of his 35 passes for 155 yards and found tight end Lacota Dippre in the end zone twice for touchdowns. That vaunted Texas defense, coached up by Will Muschamp and led by national sack leader Colin Simmons, managed only one sack on Jones, so elusive in the pocket that he must have been coated with Teflon. Like the defense on those first two Texas drives and the offensive line that didn't figure things out until the final two drives of the first quarter, Jones played like you expect a quarterback who hasn't started a football game in two years and the O-line was busy absorbing blows from that monstrous Texas front four rather than deliver the punishment.

Following a 63-yard punt return for a touchdown by All-American Ryan Niblett that gave the Longhorns a commanding 17-3 lead with 11:27 left in the first half, a jolt of lightning must have struck Jones and the Florida O-line. From that point onward, Jones was lucid, poised, decisive and in complete command of a risk-avoidance offensive game plan dialed up by Buster Faulkner. Jones spent most of the day finding open receivers for short throws, but when the Gators faced a fourth-and-12 at the Texas 36 with less than a minute to go in the first half, he delivered a 17-yard strike that Dallas Wilson caught and got both feet inbounds going against Bo Mascoe, the Longhorns' best cover corner. On the next play after that fourth down reprieve, Jones showed his wheels with a decisive 14-yard run. Two plays later he connected with Dippre on a 7-yard pass for a touchdown that cut the deficit to 17-10 with 18 seconds remaining in the half.

The touchdown drive to end the first half and the 15-play, 69-yard drive for a TD to start the second half were defining moments for Jones. In the first quarter he was tentative, choosing the easy throw even when there was an open receiver farther downfield. The final drive of the first half changed the entire complexion of the game. Working with a short field after Ty Jackson decleated Hollywood Smothers on a fourth-and-one, Jones took the Gators down the field 49 yards to a touchdown on nine plays, scoring on the pass to Dippre.

That TD drive was huge from a psychological point of view since going from down 17-3 to within a touchdown at the half took the air out of the Longhorn faithful. To start the second half, the Gators drove methodically, taking 8:03 off the clock. Two possessions later, Jones led the Gators on another time-consuming drive, this one 14 plays for 57 yards that ate up 6:31 of clock time while carrying over into the fourth quarter, ending with a 28-yard field goal by Patrick Durkin that gave UF the lead for good.

"I think he [Jones] started to do some things simple, better in the second half and just take what's there," Sumrall said. "Don't have to do anything crazy, put the ball in play, give guys opportunities and get the ball in the hands of our playmakers."

By playing turnover free and putting the Gators in plus situations on second and third downs, it backed the Texas safeties out of the box which opened up the running game for Jadan Baugh. Held to just 72 yards combined in the losses to Missouri and South Carolina, Baugh carried 25 times for 91 yards, scoring what proved to be the game-winning touchdown on an 11-yard sweep around the right side with 6:22 left in the game. On the drive, Baugh also had a 13-yard run in which he juked a couple of defenders then ran over two more before he hit the ground.

It was vintage Baugh and in large part, a statement by the O-line, whose first quarter performance was far too reminiscent of the previous two weeks. In the first quarter, the O-line struggled against the Longhorns' space eaters up front, but they went beast mode, particularly in the third and fourth quarters. In the second half, the Gators had perfect balance, 85 yards on the ground, 85 through the air.

"It's a whole lot easier to play quarterback when the O-line plays good," Sumrall said. "And so, no matter who's the quarterback for us, when the O-line plays better, it's a lot easier to play quarterback and the last couple weeks, no

secret, we haven't played very good on the O-line. This week, we played better on the O-line, so it made everything tick. Just a little bit cleaner on third down as well. We also ended up in less what felt like third and crazy extra longs today. At times where in the past, I don't have all the stats in front of me, but last week I felt like every time we looked up it was third and 12."

The long drives by the offense allowed a rested defense to dominate the second half. A 62-yard Manning to Emmett Mosley V that set up the only Texas score of the second half, accounting for all but 26 of the Longhorns' second half yards. Florida held the ball for 46 second half plays while Texas only managed 19 snaps after the halftime break.

When Texas cut the Florida lead to 27-24 and then forced a punt, the Longhorn faithful envisioned another come-from-behind win like the one against Ohio State in game two, but on second down at the Texas 48, the Gators brought the house with Myles Graham sacking Manning and forcing a fumble that Kanye Clark recovered at the UT 39. Texas still had three time outs remaining, but on third down Jones sprinted nine yards for a first down at the Texas 27, effectively ending any chance the Longhorns had of a comeback win.

Three kneels from a victory formation by Jones and it was over, Florida's first win on the road against a ranked opponent since the Gators beat then No. 6 Florida State in Tallahassee.

Make no mistake about it, this was a total team win, but considering the way the defense had played in the previous six games, their effort paved the way for the upset. Texas scored only two offensive touchdowns and managed just 272 total yards. The Gators controlled the football for 38:11 of the 60 minutes. Besides getting sacked five times for -29 yards and fumbling the ball way at the most inopportune moment, Manning was just 14-20 passing for 173 yards. Take away the one big play and he was 13-19 for 111, a miserable 5.84 per attempt.

The win revived hope among a Florida fan base that viewed the second half of the season with serious trepidation. Losing two straight will do that for you. Giving up 84 points points a lot of fingers at the defense but this was their game to shine. Getting a win on the road with the backup QB getting his first collegiate start was also an emotional lift, although Sumrall once again reiterated that he believes the Gators will win games whether it's Tramell Jones or Aaron Philo at quarterback.

What he doesn't want is for his team to lose focus just because they just beat a team that two weeks ago was ranked No. 1 nationally.

"We got better today," Sumrall said, putting it in perspective. "I think if we've learned anything about this in this game or in life, you don't get to go, yeah, it was good last week, so I get to be good next week, right? I guess part of why we got our ass kicked in Missouri and last week at home is because everybody around Gainesville was patting our guys in the back telling them how good they were. And I'm like, guys, we suck. I think I've watched this practice. We're not very good. We still suck. We just suck less. So we have to figure out how to suck less each week. But we're not like a complete team yet."

COLUMNIST · BUDDY MARTIN

# A TEXAS BARBECUE: GATORS FLIP THE SCRIPT — AND JONES CHANGES THE CONVERSATION

BY BUDDY MARTIN Oct. 18, 2026



Tramell Jones had a spectacular first start. Photo courtesy UAA and Hannah White.

> **"THE GATORS QUIT FLINCHING. LET'S SEE IF THEY CAN KEEP IT UP."**

**Buddy has not signed off; confirm before print. Draft text (Wix draft 6e802f31, unpublished), cut for the magazine per Brenden. Quotes and facts in this column are Buddy's own reporting and were not re-checked here.**

It's just not safe out there for Top Ten Teams. As Georgia found out against Auburn. As Indiana found out against Ohio State. Alabama found out in an upset by Tennessee (26-10). And Texas found out against Florida (27-24).

I'm not sure which was the most shocking.

Nobody saw the Georgia and Texas losses coming. Not the oddsmakers, not the Longhorn or Bulldog. And especially faithful not many Gator fans who'd spent two weekends watching their team get pushed around.

Florida went into Austin with a backup quarterback making his first career start and the worst defense in the Southeastern Conference. The Gators left with a 27-24 win over No. 7 Texas, upside-down "Hook 'em Horns" fingers in the air, and a season that had looked like it was over by Halloween.

Jon Sumrall didn't sugarcoat how they got there.

"We kept fighting. We didn't do that the past couple of weeks, to be honest with you," he said. "When things got tough, we flinched the last couple weeks."

Flinched. That's a coach admitting what everybody had watched. After a 4-0 start pushed Florida to No. 8, the Gators lost two straight blowouts and looked soft, confused and done. Saturday was the first time in 2026 that this team got punched in the mouth on the road and punched back.

## THE KID WHO WAITED

Remember the preseason quarterback battle? Sumrall picked Aaron Philo because he ran the offense and handled things at the line of scrimmage better. Tramell Jones Jr. was told to stay in the competition, stay ready and stay patient.

He stayed ready. Philo got hurt, and Jones got the keys in one of the toughest road environments in the country.

The start was rough. Texas went up 17-3 in the second quarter after Ryan Niblett's 63-yard punt return for a touchdown, and the crowd smelled another Florida collapse. Two weeks ago, that's where this game ends.

This time Jones hit Lacota Dippre for a touchdown with 18 seconds left in the half. Then he came out in the third quarter and led a 15-play drive that took eight minutes off the clock, finishing it with another touchdown to Dippre.

That wasn't a gunslinger show. It was a grown-up drive, the kind that wears out a defense and quiets 100,000 people a little at a time.

"I didn't take it any bigger than it was," Jones said. "It feels great, but this is just the start. It's not over."

Spoken like a kid who knows a quarterback job can change week to week. Philo will heal, and Sumrall will have a decision to make. That's a better problem than the one he had Friday night.

## SAME DEFENSE, DIFFERENT TEAM

Now the part that doesn't add up on paper.

The defense that couldn't stop anybody for two weeks held Texas under 300 yards. It sacked Arch Manning five times. After the first two Texas drives, it took away the Longhorns' big-play receivers and gave up one first down on Texas' first three possessions of the second half while Florida took the lead.

And when the game was on the line, Myles Graham got to Manning one more time and knocked the ball loose on Texas' final drive. Ballgame.

I'm not going to tell you one Saturday fixes a defense that ranked last in the league. It doesn't. But it tells you the problem may have been heart, not talent, and Sumrall can coach heart.

This one belongs among the biggest road wins in Florida football history. And rarely have the Gators flipped a script quite like this.

## BAUGH PAYS IT BACK

Patrick Durkin's 28-yard field goal gave Florida its first lead. Then Jadan Baugh broke outside for an 11-yard touchdown, and for a few minutes that felt like the game.

That's the same Jadan Baugh who had schools lining up to take him in the transfer portal. The same Baugh whose grandmother got a visit from Sumrall on Christmas Eve. Coaches make house calls for moments like this one: fourth quarter, top-10 team, their building, ball in the hands of the guy you fought to keep.

Texas answered right away. Manning slipped a fourth-down sack, found Emmett Mosley V for 62 yards and hit Cam Coleman for a 9-yard touchdown. But the Gators had the last word.

## TEXAS HAS BIGGER PROBLEMS

Steve Sarkisian looked like a man reading his own autopsy report.

"We didn't play good football today. Kind of bled out," he said.

He's right, and it's getting worse. Texas has lost two straight. Manning has struggled for four games in a row. One of the best defenses in the country gave up second-half scoring drives of 15 and 14 plays, and star edge rusher Colin Simmons left in the fourth quarter with what looked like an ankle injury.

"It's not great right now," Manning said. "Coming off two losses in a row, it stings."

## THE VERDICT

This was Florida's first road win over a top-10 opponent since 2012. Fourteen years. Think about how many coaches, quarterbacks and fresh starts have come and gone in that time.

Is Florida back? Let's not get silly. The Gators are 5-2 and go to No. 1 Georgia on Oct. 31. Jacksonville has humbled plenty of teams feeling good about themselves.

But two weeks ago, people were asking whether Sumrall's team had a spine. On Saturday in Austin, it showed one.

The Gators quit flinching. Let's see if they can keep it up.

# PRESS CONFERENCE

Template page. Nothing on this page is a quote. Quotes go in only from a full transcript, verbatim, with the speaker and the setting.

**RESERVED · PENDING TRANSCRIPT**

### HEAD COACH JON SUMRALL

*"[Opening statement: verbatim from the transcript]"*

*"[Q&A pull quote: verbatim from the transcript]"*

**JON SUMRALL, HEAD COACH · POSTGAME PRESS CONFERENCE, OCT. 17, 2026**

**RESERVED · PENDING TRANSCRIPT**

### PLAYERS AT THE PODIUM

*"[Player quote: verbatim from the transcript]"*

**[NAME, POSITION] · POSTGAME PRESS CONFERENCE, OCT. 17, 2026**

**RESERVED · PENDING LINKS**

### WATCH

*[Postgame video link: The Buddy Martin Show / GatorBait TV]*

**NO VIDEO LINKS HAVE BEEN SUPPLIED YET.**

Until the transcripts arrive, Jon Sumrall's press-conference comments as Franz Beard reported them are printed in Franz's column in this issue.

# WHAT'S NEXT: GEORGIA

Florida's next game, from ESPN.

| FLORIDA | VS | GEORGIA |
|---|---|---|
| 5-2 · 3-2 SEC | | Record and ranking pending |

| | |
|---|---|
| **DATE** | Saturday, Oct. 31, 2026 |
| **KICKOFF** | 3:30 p.m. ET |
| **TV** | ABC |
| **SITE** | Mercedes-Benz Stadium (neutral) |
| **FLORIDA** | 5-2 overall, 3-2 SEC |

## WHAT FLORIDA CARRIES OUT OF AUSTIN

**24**
**STRAIGHT POINTS**
The run that beat Texas.

**0**
**TURNOVERS**
Florida's count in Austin.

**7-55**
**PENALTIES**
Texas had 1-15.

## STILL TO COME

**PENDING**
Georgia record and ranking: pending, we print the latest release only

**PENDING**
Line and total: pending

**PENDING**
Injury and availability report: pending

**PENDING**
The desk's Georgia preview and the Buddy Martin Show preview: coming this week

Source: ESPN game summary (event 401856724) for Florida's numbers; ESPN schedule for date, time, network and site. No Georgia ranking or record is claimed here.

# MASTHEAD


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**THE GATORBAIT MEDIA DESK**
POSTGAME DESK, GRAPHICS AND PRODUCTION

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**Next: Georgia, Saturday, Oct. 31, 3:30 p.m. ET, ABC, Mercedes-Benz Stadium.**


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